

Part I

Foreward

The Bandgi Nama or “Communion with the Divine” by Sardar Raghbir Singh Bir contains the spiritual and devotional thoughts of the author, which were flashed to him in his midnight silent meditation. S. Raghbir Singh was not only a poet of a high order, but a thinker and a philosopher who had personally experienced various stages of spiritual discipline while leading a life of a successful householder-fulfilling all the obligations towards his parents, family and children imparting them the best education-academic and cultural.

Bandgi Nama originally written in Punjabi (Gurmukhi script) has been acclaimed as a veritable guide to self-realization even for a new aspirant. It has been translated into English for the benefit of English-knowing seekers, who have no approach to Punjabi. Along with the translation are published copious references from Guru Granth Sahib in Roman in support of the author’s own spiritual experiences to lend authenticity to them.

The author himself started as a layman on the spiritual path, and reached a stage through various sadhnas of spiritual discipline, from where he could reflect the vision of the Divine, for the rise of man of God - *manas te devte kie*.

Guru Nanak laid down the three principles-

- (i) prayer (*ardas*),
- (ii) effort (*sharam*), and
- (iii) sharing spiritual experience with others, *ape jape avra naam japave*.

In conformity with these fundamentals, whereas the author explains the technique of prayer and effort, he shares his achievements in the spiritual field with others and has given vent to the thoughts and ideals which were revealed unto him in his communion with The “Divine.”

Normally the translations of such spiritual thoughts and ideas fail to express the spirit contained in the original, but it is very heartening to find that the translator has maintained the original beauty of expression and the flight of imagination.

The quotations from Guru Granth Sahib and other scripture made use of in the original and in translation of the Hindu and Muslim saints addressed to the mankind, are of common heritage for the uplift of human being to a better material and spiritual life. The learned author has ably described in the book in simple language as to how one could discipline himself to undertake the course of concentration and meditation (*Simran*) in various stages of development which he himself experienced and brought unto practice in day to day living along with the normal course of mundane duties. The starting point for spiritual evolution according to the author is *Simran* (Remembrance of God), *gyan* (Divine knowledge) and the effort that lead an aspirant to understand the real nature of the Divine. The *gurbani*, says the learned author, if properly understood and practised takes an aspirant to the Path of realization.

Lastly Birji quotes profusely from the holy Granth that all efforts and *sadhnas* without God's grace, remain short of complete fulfillment of the ultimate object of the human birth -

bai prapat manukh dehurea
Gobind milan ke eh teri baria

The publishers deserve a special gratitude of the readers for providing them with this aid to spiritual advancement and it is hoped that they would attend to other writings of Birji and retrieve them from oblivion. No doubt during his lifetime Birji was shy of publication, but now that he has left these treasures to us to draw benefit from them, it is our duty to acquaint people with his thoughts, efforts and experience.

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 Calcutta,
Dated 10th February, 1981.

Part II

About the Author

S. Raghbir Singh Bir, Scion of the highly respected family of Lala Jawahar Mal Ahluwalia who was chief Engineer and in charge of the arsenal of maharaja Ranjit Singh, was born in Lahore on 7th October, 1896. He lost his mother when he was one and a half years old. At the age of four under the inspiration and guidance of his grandmother, Sardarni Bishan Kaur, who was a lady of great devotion, young Raghbir Singh began to practice "Simran." He continued this practice all through his academic career studying side-by-side Sikh History. He was married at the age of 14 to the eldest daughter of S. Sulakhan Singh of Gujranwala. She died after two years and he was married again to Sardarni Rawel Kaur, eldest daughter of S. Sundar Singh Jaspal of Kapurthala, who remained his life long companion right upto his demise. He graduated from the Khalsa College, Amritsar. During his college days he took active part in social and religious activities and wrote poetry. He grew up to be a poet of high order. His most inspiring masterpiece which he himself sang at the Sikh Educational Conference held in Lahore, was '*Bajan Walia tere school under asan sunia ke lagdi fees koi ba*', became a house hold song in many Sikh homes. The British Government banned his first Book, '*Bir de Tir.*'

The Jallianwala Bagh tragedy had a great impact on his tender mind. He entered heart and soul in the Akali movement and had to go underground several times on account of his anti-British poems.

His father S. Lena Singh was a high official in the Indian Railways, but S. Raghbir Singh refused to join British Government service. He came to Calcutta in 1922 and started his business. In 1940 he started Atam Science, a monthly Magazine. He joined in partnership with S. Niranjan Singh Talib and ran Desh Darpan, a daily Pubjabi News paper in Calcutta. In 1940 he started Gurmat Parchar Society in Calcutta for the propagation of Gurbani and Kirtan, which is still going strong. It was in Calcutta that he conceived the idea of establishing a Sikh Convent and created the Atam Science Trust in 1953.

Thereafter he established a Sikh Public School at Dagshai in 1957. Later on he created another trust known as the Gurmat Parchar Trust for the propagation of the teachings of the Guru Granth Sahib, the Holy Book of the Sikhs. He breathed his last on the 14th April 1974 at Dagshai where he spent his last 17 years solely devoting himself to the service of God, *Simran* (meditation) and to his Writings. He is the author of several books in Punjabi.

Part III

Preface

Sardar Raghubir Singh Bir's *Bandgi Nama*, written in Panjabi, has provided spiritual solace and enlightenment for the Sikhs for many years. It has now been translated into English with a view to making it available to non-Punjabi speaking readers who are interested in religious issues. Although the book is an outstanding interpretation of Sikhism it is not at all sectarian in outlook, and the followers of other religions can profit by reading it and using it as a guide for progress in their spiritual journey.

Sikhism is one of the great world religions; the teachings of the gurus transcend the limits of caste and creed as also of time and place. The universal appeal of the *Guru Granth Sahib* is evident not only in the catholicity of *Gurbani* but also in the inclusion of hymns composed by Hindu and Muslim Bhaktas. By quoting extensively from the Holy Book and explaining the essence of its leading ideas in simple language the author has not only cleared the way for a new understanding of the Sikhs view of life but also established fresh link between the Sikhs and other religious communities.

Bandgi Nama is not an academic study of metaphysical problems. It is not a philosophical dissertation, although a person whose mind was not deeply rooted in philosophical knowledge and illuminated by philosophical insight could not have written it. As a frank and convincing record of the author's own spiritual experiences it is primarily a practical guide for earnest seekers of Truth. As a true Sikh he lived the life of a householder, performing his domestic duties on lines prescribed by the Gurus but declining to be diverted from the real purpose of life by domestic entanglements. At the initial stage of his quest of Truth he asked himself the question: 'Why must I try to realize Truth?' Like many others he defied and resisted the 'inner voice,' but meditation, *Simran* metamorphosed him and 'recreated him in spirit.' He did not share the common idea that one should not divulge his spiritual experiences. He says, 'Our spiritual stock does not shrink or dwindle by sharing it with others.'

Apparently, he thought - quite rightly, that some seekers of Truth might find his experiences helpful in their difficulties.

The author was prompted to write this book by his firm belief that a correct interpretation of religion could transform men into angels and this 'world into a paradise.' In particular, he aimed at diverting the mind of the young generation tending to be 'materialistic and atheistic' under the 'influence of Westernism' - to the right path by 'unfolding to them the great

spiritual treasures we have inherited from our forebearers.’ The ‘spiritual treasures’ unfolded by him in this book are a heritage of the Sikhs in a special sense, but they form a part of India’s common heritage and provide a stimulus for nation building on the basis of abiding values.

The central aim and aspiration of the Sikh, says the author, ‘is to see God, to realize God, to be one with God.’ In his effort to achieve this ‘aim’ the Sikh seeks guidance from the Sacred Book of which the two ‘central, essential points are God and His realization through Naam.’ The Word is the substance of the teachings of the Gurus, ‘a vision of their souls, of their Spirit, of their life-experience.’ By regulating life in the light of the Word one merges-at the final stage of his spiritual journey in ‘the light of all light.’ At that stage there is ‘something indefinable, ineffable, a sense indescribable - of joy.’ One basic point-essential to all spiritual efforts-is stressed by the author ‘God cannot be realized through mere devotion, meditation, self-effort, cleverness, ritualism, or Tapas, or even merely through Simran, and God can be realized only through His own grace. Grace - the indefinable blessing’, manifests itself when we purge ourselves of self or pride, and take to *Simran*, or adoration, with our whole heart.’

The author communicates to the reader with exemplary lucidity and through apt quotations and examples, the meaning of dedication of life to One who is *Sargun*, *Nirgun* and *Nirankar*. He has written a book that should be read again and again, not only by believers in Reality, but also those who are troubled by ‘honest’ doubts.

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11 February, 1981.

Chapter 1

Introduction

‘Those who have realized the Truth
Are kings among men, indeed.
These earthly kings are no kings
To love anything except God causes pain
Why exalt and glorify what is created
It is but fleeting and evanescent
One alone lives for ever and ever
The God-centred being who realizes this Truth
He is like God, ever-living and deathless.’

Guru Amardas - Maru.

The Voice within me has ever exhorted me, "Realize God, thereby you will find within you the Eternal Bliss." For a long time, I did not heed the inner Voice. At times, I would answer this voice in the words of Bhagat Dhanna, While starving, I cannot afford that quest.

Again, out of an unfathomable ocean, as it were, there would emerge a voice from my innermost depths chiding me, "Realize God, there is no emancipation, no salvation without realization of God."

Then I laid before this voice all my doubts "Why must I try to realize God? why must I exert and close my eyes? The world is so beautiful, with its charming rivers, majestic mountains, twinkling stars, lovely sky, beautiful buildings, good friends, and soft beds. How beautiful all these are!"

At this, the voice within grew faint and I was happy that I had silenced it for good. But, again, the voice was audible with four-fold intensity “Realize God; not in vain hast thy Guru said,

“Naught save God’s worship will avail thee”

Guru Arjan - Asa.

“This life of thine is being wasted,
Thou hast fallen in love with the fleeting phenomena of the world.”

Guru Arjan - Asa.

“Naught but God’s worship will avail thee; The rest is naught.”

Guru Arjan - Gauri Sukhmani.

“The world which fascinates and enthralls thee,
looks so to thee on account of
thine own angle of vision;
He who is happy finds
The whole world in radiant joy;
To the diseased mind all are ailing.”

Guru Arjan - Sorath.

The voice further repeated:

“An object grows pretty, if you think it so. (There is nothing either good or bad but the thought that makes it so). You might think a certain river enchanting, but how does the mother view it-whose only son, with the newly wedded wife and the marriage party has been drowned in it? To her, that river, with its uncertain currents and blind wells, is a treacherous serpent. Rivers, when in spate, wash away hundreds of villages, destroying thousands of lives. You describe the hills and mountains as fascinating, but ask those whose dear ones were buried under debris in the Kangra earthquake. To them, these very hills and mountains are deathtraps! We find the stars radiant and lustrous, but ask someone suffering the pangs of separation the glimmering stars seem to mock them. The world is neither charming nor repelling, but as you view it-It is your individual angle of vision that makes all the difference.”

The inner voice continued:

“When you search within yourself, all your doubts are resolved. You will see through the heart of things; death will lose its terror; the world and its joys and sorrows will vanish, your inner latent powers will awaken and then you will transcend the world’s allurements.”

We say, “While starving, one cannot worship God,” but “None is satisfied, except when inwardly contented.” “Put thy faith in me ; Bhakti will drive away thy want. Not bread but contentment will appease thy hunger. Contentment will quench thy yearning.”

Greed will not go Nam, oneness with God
doth banish greed and sense of want.

Guru Amardas - Maru Var.

Meet thy Guru, And thou wilt find thy contentment.

Guru Amardas - Gujri.

For a long time, I procrastinated in the face of the inner voice. Whenever I acted directly in opposition to the dictates of the voice from within, it became all the more insistent and persistent.

At last, I began serious research in religion. By birth, I am a Sikh, and so I instinctively believed that I must knock at Guru Nanak’s door. Even though the sacred Granth is in the Gurmukhi script, yet it is not easy to understand it, and the Sikh ecclesiastical authorities have no provision for people in genuine spiritual stress. Those of us who have acquired Western culture, do not know where to turn for guidance. Sikhs of the old school who have no such links with Western mores cannot appreciate the difficulties of the former class.

Whenever I failed to understand a point in the sacred Book, I prayed for light and waited for it with faith and hope, and not in vain. In my meditations, I had flashes of light, and my long-standing doubts were resolved. Many a time, I lighted upon books and writings, which answered my questions so aptly that I was lured into believing that they had been written specially for me. In this manner, my uncertainties were clarified. What astonishes me is that the inner voice, which I had defied and resisted, continued to ring in my ears and has ever striven to set me on the right path. In consequence, now, I never ignore it and listen to it most intently.

This voice of the Soul keeps on prompting, goading, and urging each one of us, conveying its heavenly message. We understand and profit by it in proportion to, and in accordance with, our individual stage of spiritual enlightenment. Guided by this voice, I have read many religious books and have met enlightened souls to seek further knowledge. I had a thirst for testing the truth of spiritual doctrines.

In moments of spiritual conflict, Simran, or meditation, helps us to arrive at the Truth and the seeming contradictions vanish. I shall describe how I acted in such crises. I read religious books and consulted mahatmamas tested what they said, and noted the result. I have continued to do so, even though I have not yet attained perfection, and, at times, I am spiritually in a pitiable state. I am not at all incontinent, or given to pleasures of the flesh, and yet I cannot deny that I am impressed by feminine charm and sex appeal. This susceptibility has impeded my spiritual progress to a certain extent. Nevertheless, meditation, or Simran, has metamorphosed me and recreated me in spirit. In this new, regenerated life, there are no worries, no vexations, no cares, no sense of want, no craving for anything. There is joy, there is bliss, there is calm, peace and poise—a carefree life. The greatest material joys cannot compare with the inner bliss, howsoever brief its spell.

How can I possibly repay the debt I owe for His grace and generosity in my quest of Truth? Yet through this book, I can place on record my overwhelming gratitude. Maybe, some seekers of Truth may find this book of some help, in their difficulties.

Under the influence of Westernism, youth tend to be materialistic and atheistic. There is no point in being impatient with them, nor can we afford to neglect or ignore them. There can be no better approach to their hearts and minds than to unfold to them the great spiritual treasures we have inherited from our forbears. We must approach youth through a technique that will appeal to the hearts and minds of the intelligent and set them thinking.

In the present set-up, we cannot put our faith in things, unless we actually see their beneficial effects in our life. In fact, many people regard the realization of God, the quest for Truth and Religion itself as useless. They are not so much to blame for this attitude as some of the religious preachers who neither understand religious truths, nor live them in their actual lives, and hence fail to present the great truths to the World.

It is my firm belief that a correct interpretation of religion could transform men into angels and this world into a paradise. Religion is not to blame. It is the stupid, selfish, short-sighted preachers of religion who are really to blame. The proper solution to the difficulties of the East and the West lies in a correct dissemination of the essence and core of religion.

From God's adoration, through Simran, or meditation, countless virtues flow. A stout heart and a clear mind result from it. We become capable of grasping subtleties. Even for worldly advancement, these two practices are essential. Meditation leads to perfect health. In the first place, the man of God is a man of health and even if he falls a prey to ill-health, it is easily cured through Simran, drugless or with the minimum use of drugs. In higher stages of spiritual advancement, the terror of disease and death is entirely eliminated.

Disease and pain, illusion and fear are shed
When, saith Nanak, the Creator dwells in our mind.

*dukh bharam dard bhau nasia
karanhar Nanak man basia*

Guru Arjan - Gauri.

Meditate on Him and you eliminate
Disease, sorrow, and pain.

*rog sog sabh dukh binsahi
japat naam Murari*

Guru Arjan - Gauri.

The angels of Death torment not those
Who live and move and have their being in God.

*jo hari hari naam dhiainde
tin jamned na avai.*

Guru Ramdas - Asa.

Men of God can cure disease by their spiritual powers. The man of Simran fully realizes the truth of Guru Gobind Singh's words,

By meditation, the body is radiant like gold.
And death draws not nigh.

sada rahe kanchan si kaia
kal na kabahu biape

Guru Gobind Singh.

When and if we are at one with God, we shed all fear of mishaps and death.

If we take refuge in God
The worldly maladies afflict us not
About us there rises a protecting bastion
Disease leaves us untouched, my brother.

tati vao na lagai Parbrahm sarnai
chaugird hamarai Ram kar dukh lagai na bhai

Guru Arjan - Bilawal.

The man of Simran, the man of God, has all his elementary needs satisfied without worry. Need and want are banished.

He who lives in God
Sheds destitution and want.

tis ki trishna bhukh sabh utrai
jo hari naam dhiavai

Guru Ramdas - Asa.

Through Simran we come to know how to be in union with God, and oneness with God endows us with heavenly powers and attributes, and then we secure that treasure which the entire world consciously or unconsciously seeks and strives to find.

I have found the hidden ruby.
 I have found it, I have found it,
 Blessed the place where Thou dwellest

Guru Nanak

When Thou art with me, cares I have none;
 Since I am Thy Servant,
 Thou hast entrusted all to me;
 There is no want of wealth,
 Eat and spend what we may;
 All the lower species serve us
 Thou hast created all,
 Thou befriendest all,
 Where are friends and foes?
 When God forgives, who can call us to account?
 I have realized God
 And am supremely happy.
 in Thy will, Thou wilt crown
 All my deeds with success.

*ja tu merai val hal ta kia mohchhanda
 tudh sabh kichh mainu saopia ja tera banda
 lakhmi tot na avai khai kharchi rahanda
 lakh chaurasih medni sabh sev karanda
 ih vairi mit sabhi kitia nahi manghe manda
 lekha koi na puchhai ja hari bakhsanda
 anand bhaia sukh paia mil gur govinda
 sabhe kaj savariai ja tudh bhavanda*

Guru Arjan - Maru War.

Is it not worthwhile trying and testing whether all these virtues really flow from Simran? Do we not strive our utmost and spend most of our time in trying to achieve much inferior objects? Is not the misuse of our God-given faculties responsible for our failures, disappointments, and distractions?

The man of Simran, the man of God, takes the whole world as his patrimony, and goes about as the master of the world. All forces of the world are with him, for they are an inheritance from his Father in Heaven. He knows the meaning of the sacred verse, “Man, Thou art the Lord of this earth” and he is imbued with a kingly nature, for he realizes his Father as King of Kings.

The man of Simran becomes aware of spiritual formulae, wheresoever he walks he communes with God. Wherever he is, God is with him.

Thou art my refuge at home and abroad,
Thou art with Thy servant ever

ghar bahar tera bharvasa
tu jan kai hai sang

Guru Arjan - Dhanasri.

By God’s grace the man of Simran first overcomes evil tendencies and thereby acquires control over mind and matter, and when there is nothing more to gain, he cheerfully lays himself at the feet of his Father, unites with Him and merges in Him and it seems that the son never was; while the Father abides for ever and ever, as if the existence of the son was a mere sport of the Father.

Now I am installed on the throne of God,
Merging into him, as the wave merges into the sea,
Ram and Kabir are now one,
They cannot be distinguished.

ab tau jai chadhe singhasan
mile hai sarangpani
Ram Kabira ek bhas hai
koi na sakai pachhani

Kabir - Ramkali.

A true seeker of Truth does indeed attain to this stage.

These lofty spiritual peaks are there for God-attuned souls to survey the world with divine vision and heavenly insight. There is nothing earmarked separately for Father and Son. If only we earnestly move one step towards the realm of the Spirit, the subtlest forces of creation will flock to us, and God moves post-haste to welcome us. If only we worship God earnestly and humbly if we but take a leap towards God, we should discover the truth of Bhai Gurdasji's words:

If we move one step towards God,
God advances a hundred steps to receive us.

*Charan saran guru ek painda jae chal
satguru kot painda age hoi let hai.*

Bhai Gurdas - Sawaye.

I have recorded my spiritual experiences in this book. Possibly, all of them may not fully conform to those of another God-centred soul. I claim no infallibility for myself.

My only aim is to create in my readers a desire, a craving to seek Truth, and to hearten my fortunate co-travellers on the spiritual path.

In the course of spiritual research, doubts and delusions must arise, and they impede progress. To have them resolved, we must seek the company of holy people or saints. But it is by no means easy to find true saints who really know the Truth as Guru Nanak knew it, or are in a position to guide others. In this book an attempt has been made to meet the need of such people, to some extent at least.

Some good souls hold that we must not divulge our spiritual experiences for the following reasons:

- the masses are not qualified to grasp spiritual truths and that, therefore they suffer more than they gain;
- spiritual knowledge is something very precious, and so it should not be vulgarized;
- if we reveal our spiritual experiences, we might be guilty of self-exaltation and vanity;

- if we give away spiritual gifts, we should be left spiritually weak and famished.

I have thoroughly weighed these four objections and I hold:

- Revelation of a spiritual experience does not by any means harm anybody. In our sacred Book, the spiritual truths have been lucidly and graphically depicted, and each and every Sikh is duty-bound to disseminate them.
- Spiritual truths are certainly rare, invaluable things. But due to keeping them sealed and hidden in our bosoms, and for want of dissemination, seekers of Truth have grown rare. Some people seem to think that spiritual knowledge is a hobby of leisured people, who have nothing else to do! On the other hand, there was a time when nobody was considered fit for material advancement or for any other vocation, unless he had first acquired spiritual knowledge. Instruction in spiritual matters was then a part of basic education.
- He who, with the best of intentions and for the common good, reveals his spiritual experiences, must reap as he sows. Nothing but good can come out of good. Pride is not the product of sincerity. To rise in others' esteem does engender humility in many, and a truly God-centred soul values his spiritual growth and spiritual gifts or exaltation far more than the world's esteem and honour.
- Spiritual gifts do not shrink or dwindle when we share them with others. In this case too, we can apply the rule, "as we sow, so shall we reap." If the motive in propagating and disseminating spiritual truths is pure, its fruit must be good and beneficial.

There was a time when I regarded meditation in seclusion alone as virtuous, and, in fact, a seeker of Truth must do so in the initial stages. I acquired a love for Simran from my grandmother. For about 25 years I performed Simran in seclusion, and even my wife and children and friends never knew anything about it. I used to wake up at dead of night and would go to bed early in the morning in secret. But after a certain stage in my spiritual progress, I thought it selfish to keep my spiritual experiences to myself. To put our experiences before humanity is to enrich and extend the stock of human experience. As Madame de Stael puts it, "Search for Truth is the noblest occupation of man and its publicity is a duty."

In this book I have made an attempt to narrate my personal experiences briefly and faithfully, without any exaggeration or embellishment. By so doing I have not lost anything spiritually; in fact, it has done me much good and as I progressed with my manuscript, many of my thoughts were clarified and confirmed.

The more water we draw from a well, the more and fresher water sprouts from the bottom. Our spiritual stock does not shrink or dwindle by sharing it with others; in fact, it increases. About this spiritual treasure, the Guru says

If the brotherhood of man spend the spiritual treasure lavishly,
It shrinks not, dwindles not.
Saith Nanak, this treasure is shared by those
On whom descends His grace.

*Khavēh harchēh rāl mil bhai
tot na avai vadho jai
kaho Nanak jis mastak lekh likhai
so et khajanai laia ralai.*

Guru Arjan - Gauri.